

Liberty County — What Needs a Permit, and What Doesn't

Updated September 17, 2026 · HB 803 exemptions, effective July 1, 2026

THE ONE-LINE VERSION. Cosmetic work on a single-family home, under \$7,500, no trades involved, not in a flood zone. Everything else needs a permit.

Exempt — no permit needed

All six conditions must be true. If you cannot check every one, a permit is required.

1	Single-family home
2	Strictly cosmetic, non-structural work
3	Total declared value under \$7,500 (materials + labor)
4	No electrical, plumbing, mechanical, gas, or structural work
5	NOT in a designated flood hazard area
6	Not a larger job split up to stay under the threshold

Typical work that qualifies:

Category	Examples
Flooring	Carpet, tile, vinyl, laminate, hardwood — replacing floor covering
Cabinets & countertops	Swapping cabinets or counters, provided no plumbing or wiring is moved
Painting	Interior or exterior, no surface preparation that alters structure
Drywall finishing	Patching, taping, texture, skim coat — not replacing structural sheathing
Trim & fixtures	Baseboard, crown, door and window casing, shelving

Always needs a permit — no matter the cost

These are excluded at ANY dollar value, even \$50.

Trade	Examples
Electrical	Adding or moving an outlet, switch, light, panel, or any wiring
Plumbing	Moving a sink, toilet, or any supply or drain line
Mechanical / HVAC	Ductwork, air handler, condenser, ventilation
Gas	Any gas line, appliance connection, or propane work
Structural	Load-bearing walls, framing, headers, beams, roof structure, foundation

TWO THINGS THAT VOID THE EXEMPTION OUTRIGHT. A designated flood hazard area — the exemption does not apply there at all, regardless of cost or scope. And project splitting — breaking one job into pieces to stay under \$7,500 is prohibited, and the whole job is treated as one project.

The second exemption: temporary hurricane and flood walls

A separate HB 803 exemption with NO dollar threshold. Installation of a temporary residential hurricane or flood wall that meets the specified standards requires no permit.

CONFIRM BEFORE WAIVING. Which standard the wall must meet has not been settled in the department's written materials. Check with the Building Official before telling anyone this exemption applies — do not waive a permit for a flood wall on this page alone.

At the counter

Exempt work	Have them complete the Written Request for Exemption (HB 803) before work begins. Staff verify flood hazard status — a signed form does not establish it.
Not exempt	Normal permit process. Plan review is included in the permit fee; there is no separate plan review charge.
Unsure	Treat it as requiring a permit and ask the Building Official. Work done without a required permit is charged DOUBLE the permit fee.

Questions on any specific project: Liberty County Building Department, (850) 643-2215.